RELEASE MANAGEMENT RULEBOOK

Practical governance, planning, deployment, validation and rollback guidance

Purpose
A practical reference for managing application and enterprise releases in a controlled, auditable, and repeatable way. Adapt the controls to your organisation's policies, technology, risk appetite and regulatory obligations.

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This document is a reusable operational template, not a substitute for an organisation's approved change policy, security standards, or emergency procedures.

1. Purpose and scope

This rulebook defines minimum controls for planning, approving, coordinating, implementing and reviewing releases. It can be adapted for SAP ERP/S/4HANA, business applications, integrations, infrastructure, data platforms and cloud services.

Objectives

• Protect production stability, availability, data integrity and security.

• Ensure every production release is authorised, traceable, tested and recoverable.

• Coordinate dependencies, business communications, technical teams and support coverage.

• Maintain evidence for audits and continuous improvement.

2. Core principles

• **No approval, no production deployment.** A release must have the required change approval before implementation.

• **Evidence over assumption.** Testing, approvals, dependencies, backups and validation must be evidenced in the designated systems.

• **Separation of duties.** Where feasible, the person requesting or developing a change should not be the sole approver or independent validator.

• **Risk-based control.** Control depth and approval level must reflect business impact, technical complexity, data/security risk and recoverability.

• **Traceability.** Link the change record, release record, deployment artifacts, test evidence, approvals and post-release results.

• **Stop safely.** If a mandatory control fails or critical evidence is missing, pause deployment and escalate.

3. Release types and cadence

Release type	Typical characteristics	Minimum control expectation
Standard / low risk	Pre-authorised, repeatable, low impact, proven procedure	Approved standard model, current procedure, successful checks and logg
Normal / planned	Scheduled functional or technical change	Risk assessment, test evidence, approvals, dependency review and back
Major / coordinated	Multiple systems, significant business impact or downtime	Integrated plan, cross-team readiness review, business sign-off, commar
Emergency	Urgent action to address severe incident, security exposure or business-critical issue	Expedited approval, documented rationale, controlled implem

Release windows and cadence must be agreed with business owners and service teams. The release calendar is the source of truth for planned dates, freeze periods, conflicting activities and support coverage.

4. Roles and responsibilities

Role	Accountability
Release Manager / Coordinator	Owns release calendar, readiness checklist, cross-team coordination, go/no-go facilitation, communications an
Change Owner / Requester	Defines business purpose, scope, impact, implementation details, risk and required approvals.
Technical / Application Owner	Confirms technical readiness, deployment sequence, dependencies, validation and recovery approach.
Tester / QA	Provides test plan, results, defect status and evidence that acceptance criteria are met.
Business Owner	Confirms business acceptance, business readiness and post-deployment validation requirements.

Role	Accountability
Change Advisory Board (CAB) / Approver	Reviews risk, conflicts, impact, timing and readiness according to delegated authority.
Operations / Support	Confirms monitoring, support coverage, runbooks, alerts and operational handover.
Security / Risk / Compliance	Reviews security, privacy, regulatory or control implications when applicable.

5. Mandatory release lifecycle

Stage 1 — Request and scope

• Create or link the formal change record in the approved ITSM/change tool.

• Describe business objective, affected services/systems, scope, exclusions, users impacted and expected outcome.

• Identify owner, implementers, testers, approvers and business contact.

Stage 2 — Assess risk and dependencies

• Assess impact, outage requirements, data/security/privacy exposure, complexity, reversibility and business criticality.

• Identify upstream/downstream systems, interfaces, batch jobs, transports, integrations, infrastructure and vendor dependencies.

• Check the release calendar for collisions, freeze windows, business events and other changes.

• Define the risk rating and approval path using the organisation's approved matrix.

Stage 3 — Build and test

• Use controlled, versioned artifacts and approved deployment routes.

• Record test scope, environment, results, evidence, known defects and acceptance criteria.

• Confirm required regression, integration, security, performance and user acceptance tests are complete.

• Resolve blocking defects or obtain documented risk acceptance from an authorised role.

Stage 4 — Plan implementation and recovery

• Document step-by-step deployment tasks, owners, sequence, estimated durations and checkpoints.

• Define pre-deployment checks, backups or recovery points where appropriate, smoke tests and success criteria.

• Define rollback or forward-fix decision criteria, actions, owners, time limits and data reconciliation needs.

• Confirm monitoring, support roster, business communications and escalation contacts.

Stage 5 — Readiness and approval

• Confirm required approvals are recorded and remain valid for the planned scope and window.

• Verify test evidence, dependencies, deployment artifacts, implementation plan and recovery plan.

• Confirm required resources, access, credentials, outage notices and business readiness.

• Hold a go/no-go review for major or high-risk releases. Record decision, attendees, conditions and time.

Stage 6 — Deploy and validate

• Execute only the approved scope, sequence and window; record actual start/end times and results.

• Use authorised accounts and approved tools; do not bypass controls to meet a schedule.

• Run technical smoke tests, integration checks, business validation and monitoring checks.

• If a critical check fails, stop further rollout where safe, notify the incident/change authority and follow the recovery plan.

Stage 7 — Close and learn

• Record deployment outcome, validation evidence, deviations, incidents, defects and rollback/forward-fix actions.

• Obtain business/service-owner confirmation where required.

• Update configuration, documentation, support runbooks and known-error records.

• Complete emergency retrospective reviews and track lessons learned to closure.

6. Go / no-go checklist

A release should proceed only when every mandatory item is satisfied or a formally authorised exception is documented.

Check	Ready? / Evidence
Change record is complete, correctly classified and in the approved status	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Scope, impacted services and risk assessment are documented	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Dependencies and release-calendar conflicts are checked	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Required tests passed and evidence is attached	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Required business, technical, security and change approvals are recorded	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Deployment artifacts, access and implementation steps are verified	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Recovery/rollback strategy and decision points are agreed	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Support coverage, monitoring and communications are ready	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Business validation and success criteria are clear	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____
Go/no-go decision and decision-maker are recorded	■ Yes ■ No Reference: _____

7. Risk, approvals and exceptions

Use the organisation's approved risk matrix and delegated authority. Do not invent or override approval thresholds locally without governance approval.

Risk assessment should consider at least:

• Business criticality and user impact.

• Service outage, downtime and recovery-time requirements.

• Technical complexity, number of systems and dependency uncertainty.

• Data integrity, security, privacy and regulatory impact.

• Test coverage, defect status, implementation familiarity and rollback feasibility.

• Timing, resource availability and concurrent changes.

Exceptions

• Document the control that cannot be met, reason, business risk, compensating controls, approver, expiry and follow-up action.

• An exception must not be used to bypass legal, regulatory or mandatory security requirements.

• If approval, access, dependency validation or a critical safety check is unavailable, do not proceed unless the approved emergency policy explicitly authorises a safe alternative.

8. Emergency release procedure

1. Record the incident or urgent business/security reason and link the emergency change.

2. Obtain the minimum approval required by the emergency policy before implementation, unless a documented policy-defined exception applies.

3. Limit scope to the minimum safe change; identify implementer, reviewer and recovery owner.

4. Run proportionate testing and verify the recovery approach before deployment where feasible.

5. Notify impacted stakeholders and support teams; execute with enhanced logging and monitoring.

6. Validate the service, document evidence and complete retrospective review within the policy-defined period.

9. Security and access controls

• Use least privilege, approved identities, controlled secrets and time-bound elevated access where available.

• Separate development, test and production environments and restrict production write permissions.

• Validate deployment artifacts and source versions; protect logs and evidence from unauthorised modification.

• Do not place passwords, tokens, private keys or other secrets in change tickets, release notes or general logs.

• Review security-sensitive changes with the appropriate security authority and follow incident-response procedures when compromise is suspected.

10. Communications and stakeholder management

• Before release: communicate scope, business impact, expected outage, timing, affected services, user actions and support contacts.

• At start: confirm implementation has begun and provide the agreed status update.

• During release: communicate delays, unexpected impacts, go/no-go changes and recovery decisions promptly.

• After release: announce outcome, validation status, known issues, workarounds and support arrangements.

• Use the agreed communication channel and keep material decisions linked to the change/release record.

11. Metrics and continuous improvement

Metric	What it helps assess
Change success rate	Share of releases completed without causing a rollback, incident or defined failure
Change-related incident rate	Production incidents attributable to changes
Deployment lead time	Time from approved/committed change to production, using a consistent definition
Emergency change percentage	Whether planning or upstream quality issues are driving urgent work
Rollback / recovery rate	Effectiveness of testing, implementation plans and release readiness
Post-release defect rate	Quality of testing and production validation
Approval and evidence completeness	Governance compliance and audit readiness

Define each metric, reporting window, source system and owner consistently. Metrics should encourage safer and more predictable delivery rather than discourage teams from reporting problems.

12. Release record template

Field	Entry
Release / change ID	_____
Business objective and scope	_____
Affected services / systems	_____
Release type and risk rating	_____
Planned window / actual window	_____
Dependencies and conflicts	_____
Test evidence / acceptance criteria	_____
Approvals and decision record	_____
Implementation owner / recovery owner	_____
Deployment and validation results	_____
Incidents, deviations and follow-up actions	_____
Business / service owner sign-off	_____

13. Governance and review

The designated process owner should review this rulebook at least annually and after major incidents, audit findings, material technology changes or changes to regulatory obligations. The organisation's approved policies, contracts,

regulatory requirements and emergency procedures take precedence over this generic template.

End of rulebook